

The Rhetorical Strategy of Metadiscourse/ Metacommentary



Metadiscourse is a rhetorical strategy used in many forms of academic writing

- Moments in the text where the author explicitly TELLS you how to interpret her words.
- In academic texts, metadiscourse occurs when the author stops arguing, stands back and tells you how to interpret his argument – where he reflects on what he is doing. This may involve making explicit his strategies (the strategy of explaining a strategy). It's similar to the project statement in your papers.

Practicing writing metadiscourse is useful – it helps you develop your ideas, generate more text, and get a better sense of both your paper's structure and how you might change direction. In clarifying things for your reader you do so for yourself, and in making explicit where you are going, you may see other paths. See *I Say* p. 126-30.

Metadiscourse is often used to:

1. Ward off potential misunderstandings.
2. Anticipate and respond to objections.
3. Orient the reader by providing a “map”– where the argument is going, where it has gone, etc.
4. Forecast & review structure and purpose
5. Qualify the nature, scope or extent of an argument
6. Alert readers to an elaboration of a previous idea.
7. Move from a general claim to a specific example.
8. Indicate that a claim is especially important

Example of Metadiscourse as rhetorical strategy

1. It is my intention in this book to show that a great...shift has taken place in America, with the result that the content of much of our public discourse has become dangerous nonsense. 2. With this in view, my task in the chapters ahead is straightforward. 3. I must, first, demonstrate how, under the governance of the printing press, discourse in America was different from what it is now – generally coherent, serious and rational; and then how, under the governance of television, it has become shriveled and absurd. 4. But to avoid the possibility that my analysis will be interpreted as standard-brand academic whimpering, a kind of elitist complaint against “junk” on television, I must first explain that... I appreciate junk as much as the next fellow, and I know full well that the printing press has generated enough of it to fill the grand canyon to overflowing. 5. Television is not old enough to have matched printing's output of junk. Neil Postman, *Amusing Ourselves to Death: Public Discourse in the Age of Show Business*.

Comment [c1]: OUTLINE PROJECT & PURPOSE

Comment [c2]: FORECAST ORGANIZATION OF ARGUMENT – map out what will happen

Comment [c3]: INSERTS CLARIFICATION and anticipates objections

Comment [c4]: DEALS WITH OBJECTIONS and clarifies position